TEAM LEAD'S PLAYBOOK

# Captain's Guide: Leading the AI Team

Navigating transition, assessment, and the J-Curve

# The Cumulative Disciplines

## No Shortcuts to Mastery

The disciplines are cumulative, not substitutive. Skipping steps leads to systemic failure at scale.

- **Prompt Craft:** The basic foundations.
- **Context:** Managing environment.
- **Intent:** Aligning with goals.
- **Specification:** Autonomous work.

*"You cannot jump to Level 4 without building the stack from the bottom up."*

# Assessing the Team

Where are your soldiers today?

# Shapiro's Five Levels

| Level | Engagement Type | The Human Role | The AI Role |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0-1 | Autocomplete | Accept/Reject Suggestions | Suggest Next Line |
| 1-2 | Coding Intern | Hands Discrete Tasks | Bounded Work |
| 3 | Junior Dev | Reads Diffs / Approves | Builds Features |
| 4 | Dev as PM | Writes Spec / Verification | Autonomous Build |

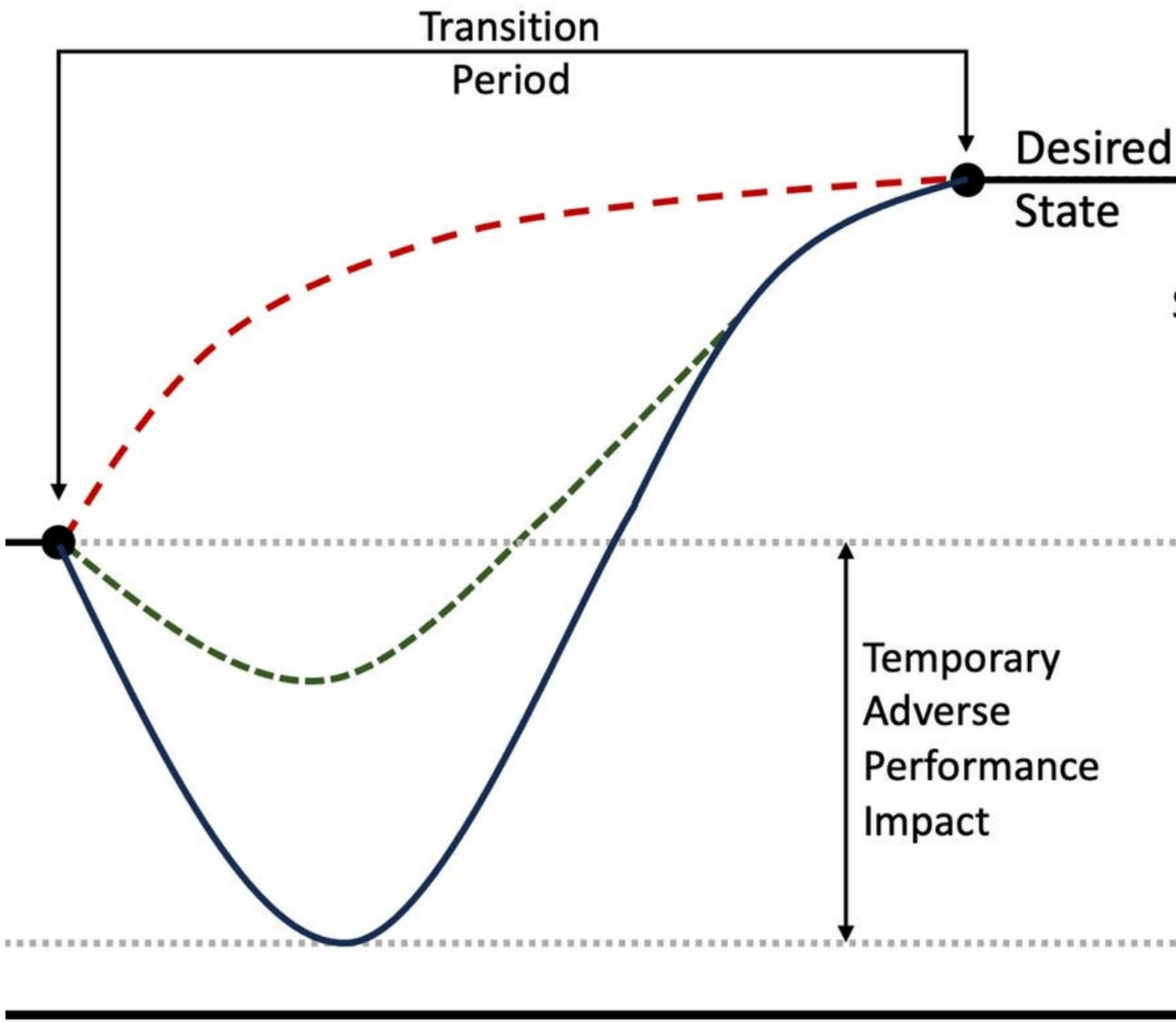
** 90% of AI-native developers currently cluster at Level 2.*

# Navigating the J-Curve

Adopting AI often makes things worse before it gets better. Why velocity dips:

- Correcting "almost-right" code.
- High context-switching costs.
- Debugging subtle AI hallucinations.

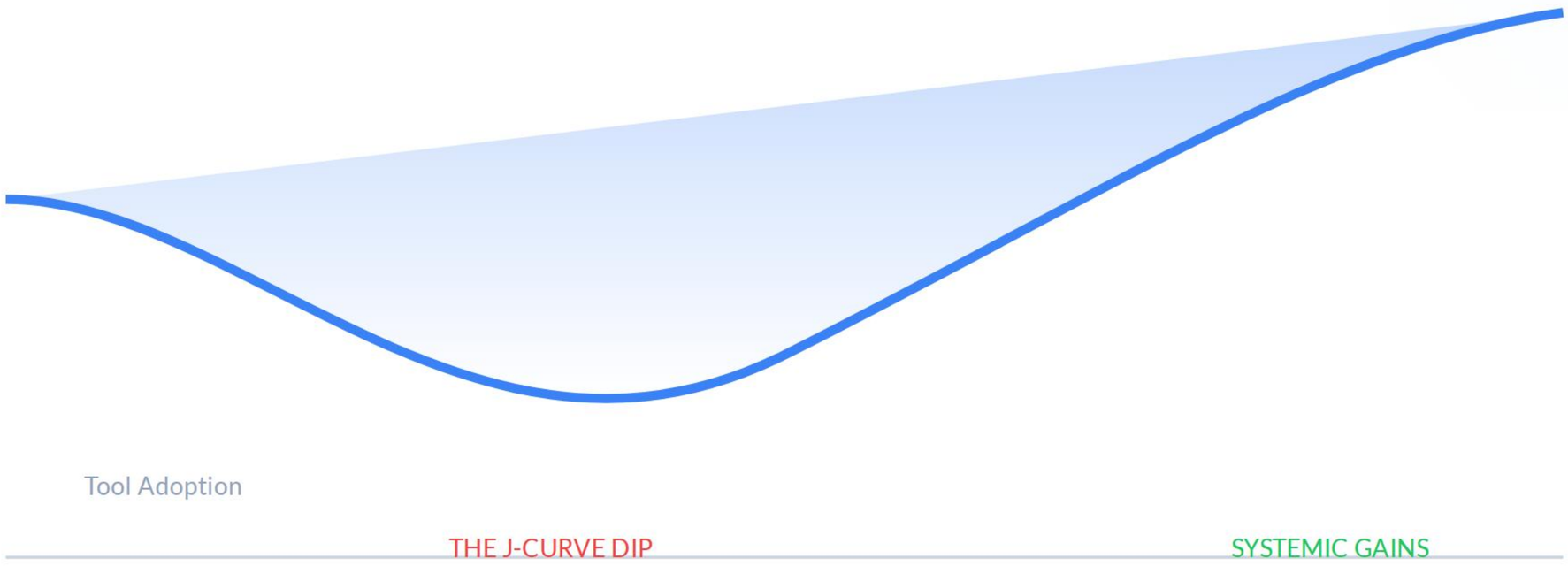
**Productivity gains require redesigned workflows, not just tools.**




t stakeholders mistakenly expect
t is possible with sound change management
t actually happens most of the time

**The J-Curve o**
by David Viney,

# Velocity Over Time




The gap between "Experienced but Slower" and "25-30% More Productive."

# Month-by-Month Plan

1

## Month 1

Close the Prompt Craft gap. Rebuild fundamentals and create baseline eval folders.

2

## Month 2

Build the context layer. Write team-level `CLAUDE.md` standards and conventions.

3

## Month 3

Master Spec Engineering. Acceptance criteria and constraints before execution.

# Implementing the Workflow

# PREVC Scale Mapping

| Project Scale | Phases | When to Use |
|---|---|---|
| **QUICK** | E, V | Bug fixes, small tweaks |
| **SMALL** | P, E, V | Simple features |
| **MEDIUM** | P, R, E, V | Regular features / modules |
| **LARGE** | P, R, E, V, C | Major features, full products |

Assign **Skills** (Expertise Modules) to each phase to provide agents the right procedures.

# Reshaping the Organization

## Coordination to Articulation

Jira, sprints, and stand-ups were responses to human limitations. Agents don't need ceremonies.

**EM:** Moves from tracker to specifier.

**PM:** Architects the spec pipeline.

**Dev:** Evaluator of outcomes.

## The Friction of Legacy

Ambiguity leads to ambiguous software. The machine does not ask clarifying questions; it builds exactly what you described.

# The 2026 Talent Profile

## Generalists

Preferring broad domain thinkers over narrow stack specialists. Understanding the "Problem Space."

## Systems Thinking

Identifying where architecture breaks under load or where logic assumptions are wrong.

## Deep Judgment

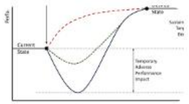
Implementation is automated; the remaining value is purely in strategic decision-making.

# Questions?

Leading the shift from **how** to **what**.

BRIEFING COMPLETE // CAPTAIN'S LOG

# Image Sources



https://substackcdn.com/image/fetch/$s_!HgLz!,f_auto,q_auto:good,fl_progressive:steep/https%3A%2F%2Fsubstack-post-media.s3.amazonaws.com%2Fpublic%2Fimages%2Fde221432-c705-40ed-a049-1d92989ccf56_1412x1000.png

Source: www.enterpriseagility.info